

Antibiotic Stewardship Program

Optimizing Antimicrobial Use to Improve Outcomes and Combat Resistance

Regulation: 42 CFR §482.42(a)(2) | CMS CoP Requirement

POLICY OVERVIEW

Antibiotic stewardship programs (ASPs) are now a CMS Condition of Participation requirement. ASPs optimize antibiotic selection, dosing, route, and duration to improve patient outcomes, reduce adverse effects, minimize selection of resistant organisms, and reduce healthcare costs.

KEY REQUIREMENTS

1 Program Leadership and Accountability

The ASP must have a physician leader (infectious disease physician preferred) and a pharmacist leader with stewardship training. Leadership must have the support and accountability of hospital administration. The program must report to the infection control committee and QAPI.

2 Core Stewardship Interventions

The ASP must implement evidence-based interventions including: prospective audit and feedback (review of antimicrobial orders with prescriber feedback), prior authorization for high-risk/broad-spectrum agents, and dose optimization based on renal function and PK/PD principles.

3 Antibigram and Formulary Management

An annual facility-specific antibiogram must be developed and disseminated to prescribers. Empiric antibiotic selection should be guided by local resistance patterns. The formulary must limit availability of agents not aligned with stewardship goals.

4 Antibiotic Time-Outs

A mandatory 48-72 hour antibiotic review (time-out) must be implemented for all patients receiving antibiotics. The review should assess: cultures and sensitivities available, opportunity to de-escalate, appropriateness of continued therapy, and transition to oral therapy.

5 Monitoring and Reporting

Process and outcome metrics must be monitored including: antibiotic days of therapy per 1,000 patient days, C. difficile rates, resistance rates for key organisms, and antibiotic expenditure. Data must be reported to prescribers and quality leadership.

COMPLIANCE NOTES

CMS added antibiotic stewardship as a Condition of Participation in 2020. The CDC's Core Elements of Hospital Antibiotic Stewardship Programs provides the implementation framework. ASPs have consistently demonstrated reduced C. difficile infection rates and improved patient outcomes.

COMMON SURVEY CITATIONS

Required under §482.42(a)(2) – Antibiotic stewardship as part of the infection control program.